

Feature Writing

Invitational A Meet • 2026



You are a reporter for the **Leaguetown Press**, the student newspaper of Leaguetown High School.

From the given information, write a **feature story** as you would for the high school newspaper. You may use statements attributed to individuals as **direct or indirect quotes**. You may not change the meaning of a statement. You have **one hour**.

Do not write your name or the name of your school on this sheet or your entry. **Put your number on your paper.**

Leaguetown High School has 868 students in grades 9-12. Over the summer, junior Steven Blue went camping with his family outside Yellowstone National Park in Wyoming. One afternoon, he went on a hike with his father and brother, freshman Kevin Blue. While walking through some large rocks, Steven stepped on one, causing the ground to open beneath him and sending him into an underground hot spring of 200-degree water and mud. His father reached out for him but was unable to get close enough because of the extreme temperature. Kevin called 911 and watched as his brother cried out in pain, struggling to get out of the spring.

The unstable ground made it difficult for Steven to swim, but he eventually pulled himself out. Severely burned and covered in blood, the family waited for an emergency medical helicopter. Steven drank all the water they had while they waited for help to arrive.

After a two-month hospital stay, seven surgeries and weeks of rehabilitation, Steven returned to school in October, just in time to try out for the school musical, "Catch Me If You Can."

On Friday, Jan. 16, Steven will star as Frank Abagnale, the lead in the musical, with three of the doctors who cared for him at the Southern Wyoming Burn Center sitting in the front row for opening night. You are writing for the issue of the Press to be distributed Jan. 14.

■ STEVEN BLUE, junior

"My brother and I go hiking at home all the time. We'd never been to Yellowstone before. I knew about hot springs, but I didn't think the ground would just open up and try to burn me alive like it did. I've never felt that much pain before in my life. I didn't think it was possible for anything to hurt that badly. It felt like scalding hot quicksand all around me, so it took a few minutes for me to finally pull myself out. I was so terrified. When I finally looked down at my body, there was blood everywhere. It looked like half of my skin had melted off. I remember being extremely thirsty and drinking all the water we had. Then I think I must have passed out because I don't remember much after that.

"Around the end of July, I was still in the hospital, but I heard the school planned to do 'Catch Me If You Can' for this year's musical. I loved the Spielberg movie, and I saw it when it first came to Broadway. Choir has always been my first love, but I've never gotten a lead role in theater before. For the first month after my accident, we weren't even sure I would ever walk again. It's unbelievable to think I'll get to sing, dance and perform for the doctors who helped save me.

■ STEVEN BLUE, continued

“The musical was exactly the thing I needed to motivate me to get through another day. Then another. Then another. Before I knew it, I was home and ready to try out. I started working with my private voice coach right away, so I knew I could still sing. The moment I saw my name next to ‘Frank’ right at the top of the cast list, it was like the burns all went away. I was me again. It took a whole army of people to get me here. All the doctors and nurses at the burn center in Wyoming were so incredible and helped me keep a positive attitude when half of my body was covered in burns. I lost a lot of skin. There were some moments after some of those surgeries that were even more painful than the hot spring itself. I’m so glad some of them will make it out to Texas this weekend to see me perform. I can’t wait to give them the biggest hug when I see them. The last time I saw them, that wasn’t even possible.”

■ KEVIN BLUE, freshman

“Without question, when my brother fell into the ground, it was the scariest moment of my whole life. I could feel the heat coming up from the ground. I know the pain he felt was unimaginable. And I felt helpless. I couldn’t dive in to help. We were in the middle of the wilderness. No hospital nearby. I just stood there. For all those weeks in the hospital, all he could talk about was ‘Catch Me If You Can.’ We watched the Leonardo DiCaprio movie and practiced some of the songs from the musical, so he would be familiar — all the while, not knowing when he’d get to go home. I can’t wait to see him in character Friday night. It’s been a long journey for him to get here.”

■ DR. AMANDA HUGHES, Southern Wyoming Burn Center

“Steven’s injuries were pretty complicated. He’s given me permission to share a little bit of his story. We had to perform multiple skin grafts, which is a procedure where we took healthy skin from his back and used it to create new skin over a lot of his burns. It’s a very painful and complicated process. I know that those weeks he spent in the hospital were not easy. We perform a lot of these procedures in my line of work, but it’s rare that we have a patient with such a great attitude who can come through such extensive injuries and jump right back into something like musical theater right away. When Steven’s dad invited us to attend on opening night, we all bought plane tickets that day. We were jumping at the chance. He’s an inspirational kid to be sure.”

■ RAY TURNAGAIN, theater teacher

“I was definitely surprised to see Steven’s name on the sheet for auditions, given all he had been through. But I have to say, he really nailed it. We did have to make a few changes to our costumes and choreography to make the performance work for him. For example, there was a scene where Frank was to come out in shorts and a T-shirt, and we changed that to a long-sleeved shirt and sweatpants. We want to keep him as safe and comfortable as possible. But with his voice, he’ll make an incredible Frank. It’s a great play loosely based on a true story about a guy trying to discover who he is and trying to outrun his past at the same time. Steven knows exactly who he is — a talented actor and singer who had a terrible accident and came out the other side of it an even better kid. Opening night can’t come soon enough for Steven.”

DO NOT DISTRIBUTE TO STUDENTS BEFORE OR DURING THE CONTEST!

Invitational A Meet • 2026 Feature Writing Contest Tips and Sample Story

Contest Director: Give one copy to each judge to use during critiquing/judging. Also, staple one copy of the contest and one copy of the contest tips to each student's returned entry. The purpose of the tips is to provide immediate feedback to students. However, it is not meant to replace written comments from the judge.

1. Figure out what the story is about and its theme or focus. This story is about a student who will appear as the lead in the school musical after recovering from severe burns.

2. The lead of a feature story must grab the reader's attention. It does not have to be a certain length or include the 5Ws and H. It should set a scene and get the reader into the story. Although you have freedom to describe the scene as you think it might have existed, try to stay close to the prompt. Judges will not want you to wander off the subject too much.

A few months ago, all he could feel was pain. But in two days, he will feel the bright stage lights as he stars as the lead in "Catch Me If You Can," this year's musical.

3. Once you get past the lead, make sure you include a nut graph. It tells the reader what the story will be about. Follow the nut graph with a direct quote and then go into the transition/quote formula. In this story, the news peg is in the lead, but additional information is required.

nut graph

While hiking on a summer trip in Yellowstone National Park with his family, junior Steven Blue fell into an underground hot spring. The almost boiling water caused severe burns and injuries, resulting in Steven spending months in the hospital.

direct quote

"I've never felt that much pain before in my life," he said. "It felt like scalding hot quicksand all around me, so it took a few minutes for me to finally reach my dad's hand for him to pull me out."

4. After the nut graph, the rest of the story can tell itself through the use of transition/quote formula. Be sure you attribute after the quote or at least after the first sentence. An attribution should be: subject of attribution followed by the verb of attribution ("Steven said" not "said Steven"). Avoid putting two or more quotes together without placing some kind of transition between them. Also, make sure transitions provide information to help the action of the story and that the quote does not repeat information in the transition.

transition/story-telling

Dr. Hughes said doctors had to perform multiple skin grafts, where they took healthy skin from his back and used it to create new skin over a lot of his burns.

direct quote

"I lost a lot of skin," Steven said. "There were some moments after some of those surgeries that were even more painful than the hot spring itself."

5. Always use third person. Don't say "our student" or "our students." Also, do not editorialize. For instance, you should not say "Go Steven!" These statements are personal opinions and should not be used in a feature story.

6. Always use the verb "said" as the verb of attribution. Don't say "says," "stated," "feels" or any other synonym for "said."

7. Finally, look for a strong quote to use as a closing statement or a statement that will bring the reader back to the beginning of the story. It should give the reader a sense of satisfaction or resolution.

And if he hadn't received enough care and support from Wyoming doctors during his recovery, three of them, including Dr. Hughes, will fly to Texas to be in the front row on opening night.

"I can't wait to give them the biggest hug when I see them," Steven said. "The last time I saw them, that wasn't even possible."

SAMPLE STORY

A few months ago, all he could feel was pain. But in two days, he will feel the bright stage lights as he stars as the lead in “Catch Me If You Can,” this year’s musical.

While hiking on a summer trip in Yellowstone National Park with his family, junior Steven Blue fell into an underground hot spring. The almost boiling water caused severe burns and injuries, resulting in Steven spending months in the hospital.

“I’ve never felt that much pain before in my life,” he said. “It felt like scalding hot quicksand all around me, so it took a few minutes for me to finally reach my dad’s hand for him to pull me out.”

Steven looked down to see much of his skin was gone. He drank all the water the family had while they waited for the emergency medical helicopter to take them to a nearby hospital.

“Steven’s injuries were pretty complicated,” Southern Wyoming Burn Center’s Dr. Amanda Hughes said. “I know that those weeks he spent in the hospital were not easy.”

Hughes said doctors had to perform multiple skin grafts, where they took healthy skin from his back and used it to create new skin over a lot of his burns.

“I lost a lot of skin,” Steven said. “There were some moments after some of those surgeries that were even more painful than the hot spring itself.”

While recovering, he heard about the upcoming musical and immediately began preparing to audition in the fall.

“The musical was exactly the thing I needed to motivate me to get through another day,” he said. “Then another. Then another. Before I knew it, I was home and ready to try out.”

He began preparing for the audition with a private vocal coach as soon as he left the hospital and returned home in October.

“The moment I saw my name next to ‘Frank’ right at the top when they posted the cast list, it was like the burns all went away,” Steven said. “I was me again. It took a whole army of people to get me here. All the doctors and nurses at the burn center in Wyoming were so incredible and helped me keep a positive attitude when half of my body was covered in burns.”

With all he had been through, theater director Ray Turnagain was surprised to see Steven’s name on the audition sheet, but Turnagain said he nailed the audition. The crew only made a few adjustments to the production, including costumes that would protect Steven’s skin and small changes to choreography.

“Steven knows exactly who he is — a talented actor and singer who had a terrible accident and came out the other side of it an even better kid than he was before,” Turnagain said. “Opening night can’t come soon enough for Steven.”

And if he hadn’t received enough care and support from Wyoming doctors during his recovery, three of them, including Hughes, will fly to Texas to be in the front row on opening night.

“I can’t wait to give them the biggest hug when I see them,” Steven said. “The last time I saw them, that wasn’t even possible.”